PART VI · HARMONY IN MUSIC · TIPS

When the harmony goes wrong

Every chord can be right and the music still sound wrong: the ending will not close, or the left hand fights the tune. The slip is in how the chords move. Find which move it is, then fix that one.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The end does not feel finished	**the cadence**: end with V → I	p. 136
A sharp or flat surprises you	**a guest**: sharps go up, flats go down, one key	p. 133
The left hand fights the tune	**the main notes**: pick the cake holding them	p. 139
A new song feels hard to learn	**the trip**: find I, IV, V and vi by number	p. 141

Four ways to hear the harmony

1. **Hum the bass**
   Sing the lowest notes: they show where the chords move.

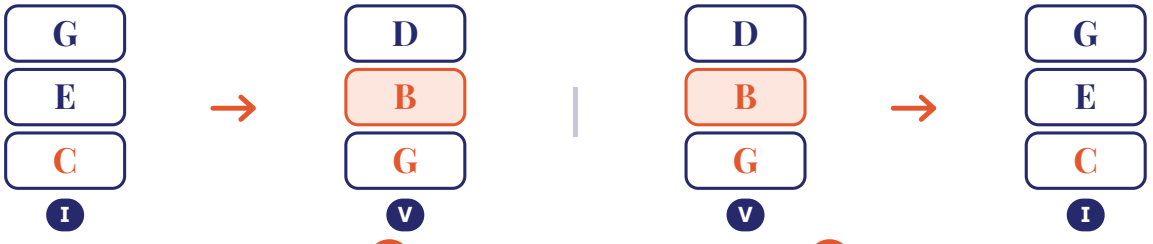
2. **Tick the full stops**
   Mark every V → I in your piece with a red tick.

3. **One trip, three keys**
   Play I–V–vi–IV in C, G and F: same numbers, new letters.

4. **Chord a tune you know**
   Pick I, IV or V for each bar of Twinkle or Happy Birthday.

EXAMPLE

Fix the ending



1. **The piece stops, but it does not feel finished.** Look at the last two chords.
2. **Name them:** C then G is I → V. That is a comma, not a full stop.
3. **Swap the order:** G then C is V → I. The red B climbs one key to C, and the music lands.

A strong ending needs **V → I** (IV → I for a soft Amen): the last two chords are the full stop.

THINK OF IT Like a road trip: once you know where home is, every detour makes sense, and every road leads back to I.